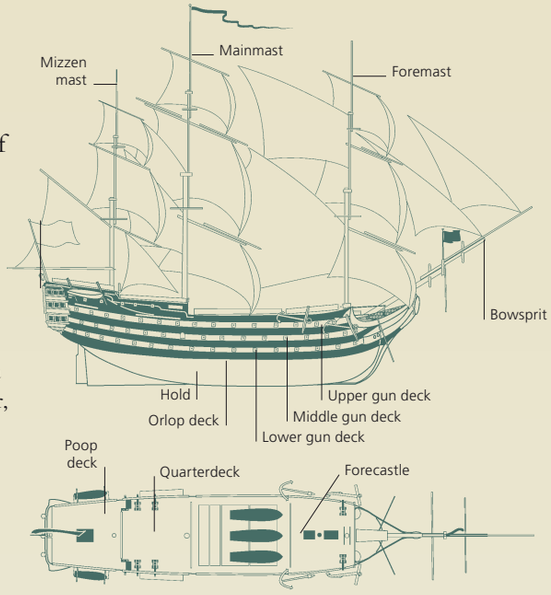
SHIP OF THE LINE

HMS *Victory* was a "first rate" ship of the line, mounting 104 guns and requiring a crew of around 850 men. It was an extremely expensive capital investment, costing £63,175 to build – equivalent to perhaps £50 million in today's money. At least 6,000 trees, mostly oak, were felled for its construction. The ship won immortal fame as Nelson's flagship when the Royal Navy defeated the Spanish and French at the battle of Trafalgar in 1805.

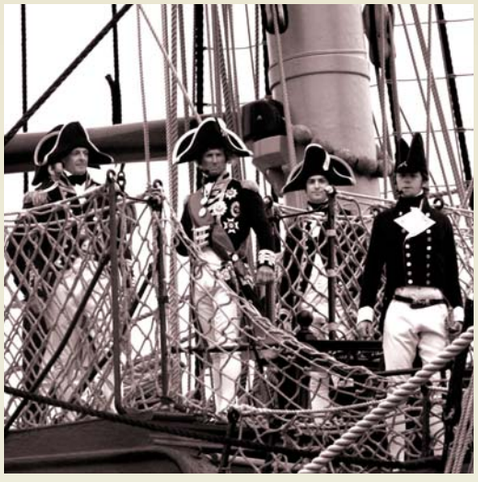
HMS *Victory* was launched at Chatham dockyard on 7 May 1765, but it was not commissioned until Britain went to war with France in 1778. During the French Revolutionary Wars (1792–99) it became the Royal Navy's flagship in the Mediterranean and led the action that destroyed the fleet of France's ally Spain at the battle of Cape St Vincent in 1797. After this triumph the ageing *Victory* was declared "defective" and relegated to service as a hospital ship. But from 1800 it underwent a major rebuilding and returned to service as Nelson's flagship in 1803.

Two years later, on 21 October 1805, it played a prominent role in the famous action at Trafalgar, losing 57 men killed, including its admiral.

Victory was known as a three-decked warship because it had three gun decks. The heaviest of the ship's guns, the 32-pounders, were on the lower gun deck, the 24-pounders on the middle gun deck, and the 12-pounders on the upper gun deck. As well as the three gun decks, however, there were three upper decks – the forecastle, the quarterdeck, and poop – as well as the orlop deck and hold below the waterline.



Side and aerial view of HMS Victory
The gun decks were 57m (186ft) long and the ship was 16m (52ft) wide at its broadest point. The masts and spars supported a total of 37 sails.



On the poop deck
Re-enactors take the roles of Admiral Nelson, the captain of the ship, and some of the officers standing on the poop deck surveying the action on the quarterdeck below.

> "EVERY GUN WAS GOING OFF ... THERE WAS THE FIRE FROM ABOVE, THE FIRE FROM BELOW ... THE GUNS RECOILING WITH VIOLENCE ... THE DECKS HEAVING AND THE SIDES STRAINING."
>
> **LEWIS ROTELY**, MARINE 2ND LIEUTENANT, ABOARD HMS *VICTORY*, OCTOBER 21 1805



Stern windows
Behind the three rows of windows in the stern were the cabins of the admiral, the captain, and the other officers.



High lanterns
The high stern lanterns, fuelled by whale oil, helped the ships of the fleet to maintain formation at night.



Powder horn
Each gun captain carried a cow horn filled with powder to prime the gun.



Gun port
This long gun has been run out of the gun port but the tampion would have to be removed from the muzzle before it could fire.